Johnny Behind the Deuce

By Lydia Lunch

WOMAN, late 30s, beautiful but weary, dressed in tight white slip and '50s-style Fredrick's of Hollywood high-heeled bedroom slippers enters stage right, finishing a cocktail. Soft amber light shadows the stage. Monologue is tender and reflective.
SCENE: A stage
TIME: The present

INTRODUCTION

Johnny is covered in scars which are self inflicted. He cuts himself again and again. You may be wondering why someone would intentionally harm themselves. Many people who cut themselves, do this in an attempt to try and release all the emotions they are feeling internally. Others may feel so numb, that seeing their own blood when they cut themselves, helps them to feel alive because they usually feel so dead inside. Some people find that dealing with physical pain is easier than dealing with emotional pain.

Self-injury is also used as a way to punish oneself. Some people have such hatred for themselves and their bodies that they will carve demeaning names on their bodies as a way to remind themselves of how terrible they are. Whatever form of self-injury is used, the person is usually left with a peaceful and calm feeling afterwards.

The following selection; however does not focus on Johnny, but rather on Lydia and the pain she feels as someone who loves a self-mutilator, someone who wants desperately to help, but cannot reach into the depth of Johnny's pain. Johnny Behind the Deuce by Lydia Lunch

WOMAN: You can't save anyone from themselves. You will lose everything by attempting to play savior. You will never heal the wounded. You cannot repair the damage already done by selfish parents, vicious ex-lovers, child molesters, tyrants, poverty, depression or simply chemical imbalance.

You can't undo psychic wounds, bandage old scars, kiss away ancient

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bruises. You can't make the pain go away. You can't shout down the voices in people's heads. You can't make anyone feel special. They will never feel beautiful enough, no matter how beautiful they are to you. They will never feel loved enough, no matter how much you adore them.

You will never be able to save the battered from battling back at a world they've grown to hate. They will always find a way to pick up where the bullies have left off. They will in turn become bullies. They will turn you into the enemy. They will always find a new method in which to punish themselves. Thereby punishing you.

No matter how much you've convinced yourself that you have done absolutely everything in your power to prove your undying devotion, unfaltering commitment, and unending encouragement, you will never be able to save a miserable bastard from himself. The wounded will always find a way to spread their pain over a vast terrain, like an emotional tsunami which devastates the surrounding landscape. An ever expanding firewall which will singe everything and everyone in its wake. The longer you love a damaged person the more it will hurt you.

They will mock your generosity, abuse your kindness, expect your forgiveness, try your patience, sap your energy and eventually kill your soul. They will not be happy until you are as miserable as they are.

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Then their incredible self-loathing will be justified by the perpetuation of a cycle from which there is little recourse. Once you enter their free fall, it will be virtually impossible to turn your back on them. You will be racked with guilt, frustrated by your own impotence and made furious forever buying into their bullshit in the first place. Of course the more damaged, the more charismatic. The more brilliant. The more sexually intoxicating. The more dangerous to your own mental health.

I have spent months, possibly years, comatose on park benches, tracking the periphery of playgrounds, skulking through shopping malls, falling asleep in the library trying to capture and trap a fleeting image.

The image of a young boy, at just the right moment in his life, that transient fleeting second when the right amount of natural light falls on the hollows of his cheeks, casts an effervescent glow, a splash of sunlight dancing on the lips, to rebirth within me, at least for an hour or two, that blossom of purity etched deep within their innocent smile.

There's something about how fine their bones are. Under their flesh. The possibility of shattering them under my need. Skin pulled tight around bony joints. The flattering reflection of my own beauty divorced of disease, my multiple sicknesses, a withering away abated. Transformed into a healing tonic, a sexual salvation, vacation from the

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devastation that has ringed the wellspring of my life.

Not that I could ever forget how much of my life has already been melted away. How much I gave up, gave over, wasted. How much has already been stolen. Destroyed. How many rope burns have left their browning residue around my heart strings. You don't have to fight yourself too hard to fall in love at least for half an hour, 20 minutes, 2 days, a week, with a young boy who finds in you the love they never found in their own mother's arms. And reciprocates it twofold. I'll play Mommie. I need to and I'm good at it. There's nothing to lose and what it is you gain is their life force, a transformation, resurrection, a reckoning, a day off from playing wet nurse in the trauma unit nursing damage junkies back to health.

But I'm too far gone now, too messed up. Broken down, battered. Nothing left inside my angel's saving graces, that busted little cherub with dirty feet and greasy wings whose tender ruby rich kisses have resuscitated so many burning embers and dying remains that I have become a mortician's re-animator, stuck forever in that purgatory limbo essence that so many dying men have come to rub their poison against.

Even my breath has become toxic. An aerosol taint of glue, sugar water, paint fumes, dead roses and runoff. But young boys don't know that yet. Don't see it, can't smell my true essence over the sweat of

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their own passion. Over the smell of their own vinegar, salt water taffy, dirty towels, steam heat. They wouldn't recognize it even if they did. They have no reference point. No landmarks. No track record. No wars under their belt.

No idea what it's like to inhabit this fleshy prison of blood and bones, entombed as if in an unnamed Nuremberg Cathedral which forty years later still remains swept to the side of a blood stained street, the bones of her confessional stacked helter skelter shattered under the steel rods, the rebar of the enemy pilot jets who blew in one day with the taste of her death on their breath, and in their wake, there she still stands, torn to little pieces praying to be glued back together again.

Praying for resurrection, for redemption. Praying with blind faith and stupid adoration to a cruel and vindictive god that does not exist, that one day the wounds will heal-That a dark angel will tumble down from the heavens, your name on his lips, and with a single kiss, the multiple fractures where memory and madness commit soul murder will cauterize. Will mend. Dissolve. But as with most prayers, I'm wasting my breath.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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